

Flicka Austria

Job Simulation Reflection

Forage Merchandising Job Simulation

18 September 2026

For this first assignment, I chose to complete the Forage merchandising simulation, relating closely to my major, marketing. This simulation allowed me to step directly into the shoes of a merchandising analyst, where I had the opportunity to prepare for a seasonal product launch. Across four distinct module tasks: building an on-order log with pivot tables, designing a Canadian line sheet, calculating full-price sell-through metrics, and conducting a competitor analysis, I was able to personally experience how data, design, and market strategy actually came together in a business. This experience gave me a clear understanding and sense of how I want to shape my brand and the potential job opportunities I want to get into as I prepare for my future career.

The simulation began with raw order data from global and regional markets across the United States, Canada, and Europe, spanning both online and physical store channels. My job as part of a merchandising team was to analyze the orders and the inventory data for our new collection into an on-order log using Excel pivot tables to figure out what the numbers were actually telling us. Going into this first task, I had somewhat of an idea of how to use basic formulas, but building pivot tables from scratch to analyze inventory compelled me to think like a planner. I was required to look at unit volumes, order values, and average prices per unit to make sense of the regional demand. During this first task, I was surprised at how easy it was for high-level numbers to hide crucial details. On the surface, the United States was our biggest market overall, but when I broke the numbers down by sales channel, I was able to identify how our European customers were buying far more through e-commerce, while our Canadian shoppers preferred buying products in our physical stores. Meanwhile, the United States was fairly evenly split between online purchases and in-person shopping. Discovering this made me realize that inventory management is not just about shipping products where sales are the highest; it is also about putting the right stock in the correct channel so customers can actually purchase it. This portion of the simulation taught me that real data analysis is not just about manipulating numbers in a spreadsheet; it is also about asking the right questions to solve real operational problems when it comes to merchandising.

For my second task module, I shifted from placing data in Excel to designing a retail line sheet for our store teams in Canada. I learned that a line sheet is essentially a visual catalog that store managers and buyers use in order to see upcoming collections, plan visual displays, and train their staff before products hit the store floor. There was no template provided for this module; my task was to get creative and figure out how to arrange the images, style names, colorway the hex codes, retail pricing, and order quantities in a way that was both visually appealing and practical to read. I felt that working on the line sheet was a refreshing shift because it allowed me to bring a creative perspective into such a structured task. I learned that a line sheet can act as a bridge between the corporate planning and the store-level execution. If my document was cluttered or confusing, store teams won't be able to do their jobs effectively. Designing a clean, creative, and functional line sheet taught me how essential clear visual communication is when it comes to retail. Through this module, I was able to see how being a

strong merchandiser is not just about being good at math or data analysis; it is also about knowing how to present information clearly so everyone on the team can be on the same page.

The third module focused on daily performance tracking, using numbers along with full-price sell-through metrics. I gathered that “sell-through” tells you what percentage of your stock was sold at its original price before any discounts or markdowns were applied. Calculating sell-through rates for different styles gave me direct insight into how merchandisers make quick, real-time inventory decisions. For this task, I analyzed products like the EcoActive Tee, CozyVibe Hoodie, and the UrbanSport Shorts, and they illustrated how quickly things can change once products were launched to customers. During this task, I saw that the EcoActive Tee beat its targets, meaning we as a team needed to act fast to restock and maximize sales at full price. On the other hand, the UrbanSport Shorts fell behind target goals, signaling that we needed to adjust our approach; it could either be by moving our store placement of the item or by planning a targeted promotion before we ended up stuck with excess inventory. I realized how proactive merchandising had to be in this portion of the simulation; waiting until the end of the season to fix sales issues leads to massive markdowns and lost profit, so tracking sell-throughs daily gives us the chance to make small, smart adjustments before minor delays turn into major financial problems.

For my final task in the simulation, I worked beyond internal data and conducted a competitor analysis comparing Alo Yoga and Athleta. While evaluating these two brands, I understood how different retail strategies play out in the activewear market. Alo Yoga focuses heavily on an inspirational, luxury image with neutral color palettes, limited-edition drops, and influencer partnerships, rarely discounting or marking down their products, while Athleta takes a different approach; they focus on inclusivity, broad product ranges for multiple sports, vibrant seasonal colors, and frequent promotional events to drive and inspire volume. I found that the most valuable part of my whole simulation was comparing my findings against industry benchmarks and real-world company examples. It required me to reflect on my own analysis and see where my thinking aligned with industry standards and where I could have researched deeper; it also reminded me that internal sales numbers only tell half of the story, like in my first task. For this last part of the module, I found that in order to make smart business decisions, you always have to understand what your competitors are doing: how they price their products and how they interact with customers are all just as important as data analysis and line sheets.

After finishing this job simulation, I feel much more confident in my ability to handle real-world merchandising and marketing tasks. Not only was I able to learn how to create pivot tables, line sheets, and calculate sell-through percentages, but I also learned how all of these pieces fit together to build a successful brand strategy in not just merchandising, but a professional business as well. Comparing my work against the company examples given to me in the simulation conveyed what executive-ready work truly looks like, and it also inspired me to raise my own standards in terms of marketing. This assignment has given me practical skills such as inventory management and merchandise planning, greater analytical confidence, and a much clearer vision of the kind of thoughtful, adaptable professional I want to become as I continue to build my personal brand and what I look for in my future career.